

“I hope **Thieu understands ...** that this may be his **last crack** at **massive US support.**”

HENRY KISSINGER, IN A CABLE TO AMBASSADOR ELLSWORTH BUNKER, MARCH 1971

» AFTER

In October, Nguyen Van Thieu was reelected as president of South Vietnam, albeit amid charges that the election was rigged in the incumbent's favor.

THE ONE-MAN ELECTION

In 1971, Thieu forced a list of criteria for presidential candidates through the National Assembly that not even Vice President Nguyen Cao Ky could satisfy. One popular general met the criteria, but chose not to run despite **CIA efforts** to pay him to stay in. Thieu went to the polls **unopposed** in October and received almost 80 percent of the vote, with a 90 percent turnout. Thieu's own ambassador to the US wrote that this election only reinforced the image of the regime inside and outside of Vietnam as a corrupt and repressive **dictatorship**.